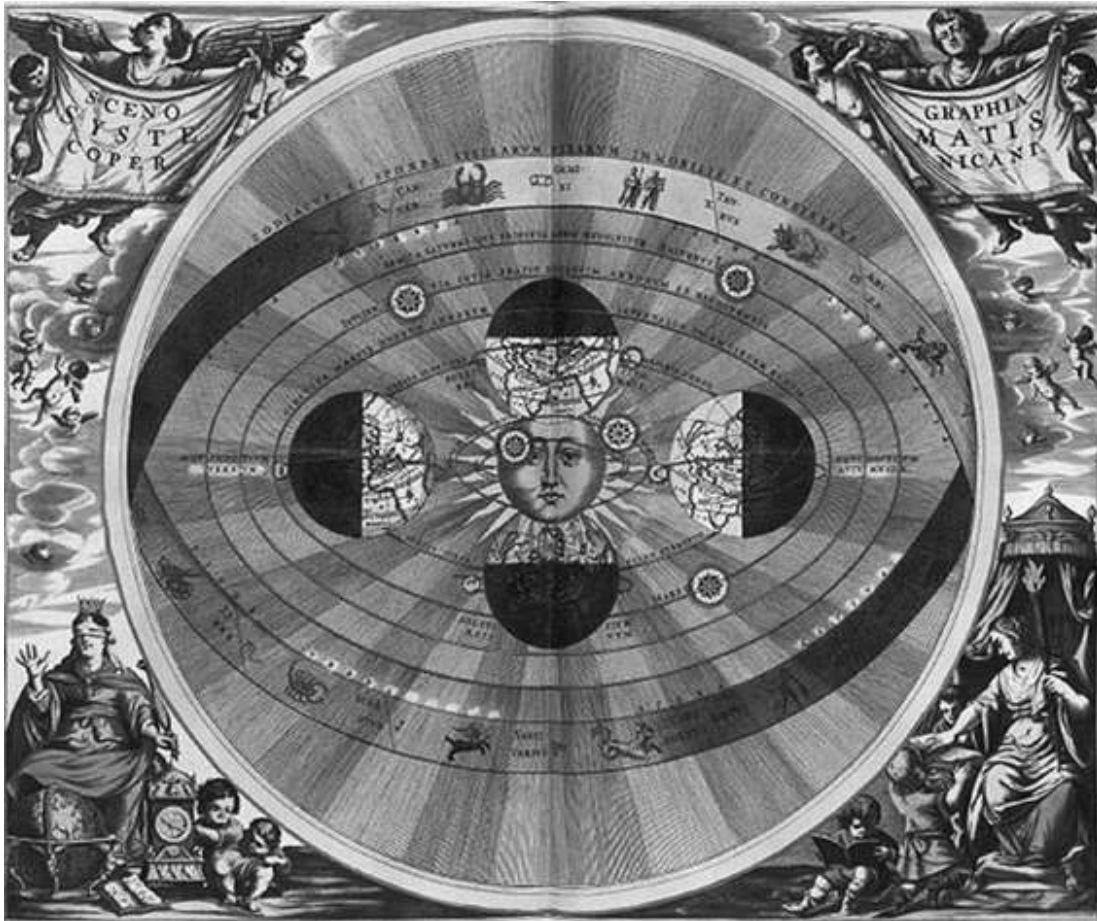


Renaissance, reason and revolution



Copernicus's idea of a heliocentric universe undermined the authority of the Church and marked the beginning of a scientific revolution.

After about a millennium of control, the Catholic Church lost its stranglehold on European cultural and intellectual life in the Renaissance, allowing philosophers to turn their attention to more humanistic concerns. The emergence of new secular powers aroused a renewed interest in political philosophy. At the same time, science (in the guise of 'natural philosophy') gradually asserted its own authority. Nicolaus Copernicus's 1543 assertion that Earth was not the stationary centre of the universe was just the beginning of a scientific revolution overturning ecclesiastical dogma. The subsequent work of scientists such as Galileo and Francis Bacon paved the way for a more systematic method that influenced all aspects of science and philosophy. This led to the so-called Age of Reason,

or Enlightenment, of the 17th and 18th centuries, producing the great schools of thought that set the agenda for philosophy in the modern era: rationalism in mainland Europe and empiricism in Britain – but also the political philosophies that led to the establishment of modern democracies.